

BFD TUTORS

Writing an Essay

A COMPLETE GUIDE TO ACADEMIC ESSAY WRITING

Sam Finnegan-Dehn

sam@bfdtutors.com · www.bfdtutors.co

TABLE OF CONTENTS

Introduction.....	3
Orientate your Essay.....	4
Evidence and Logical Reasoning.....	6
Answering the Question.....	9
The Complete Process.....	11
A Final Note.....	12

PART ONE

Introduction

This guide is the one I wish I had at university. I didn't do badly at university, far from it - but I did find myself in situations where a few more marks on a paper would've changed whole grades.

This guide helps solve that problem. It brings together knowledge from over 8 years of experience within academic settings: 4 years as a student, and 4 years as a tutor.

Starting when you choose or receive the question, the guide outlines key tips that will help you build an excellent response.

If you or anyone you know is currently facing the usual pressure and panic that comes from writing an essay at university, then this is **your guide**.

WHAT YOU'LL LEARN

- How to identify the hidden claim in any essay question
- How to research and evaluate evidence correctly
- How to use logical reasoning as a philosophical tool
- How to structure your answer for maximum clarity
- Two techniques to ensure your essay always answers the question

Work through this guide in order. Each section builds on the last.

Orientate your Essay

Every question contains a claim

This is the first step to producing clarity in your essay: orientate yourself. To do this, you need to establish the implicit claim in the question. Every question has a claim, but it isn't immediately obvious what it is, so your first task is to find it.

Using the following question, I'll walk you through how to do it:

"To what extent does Sartre's claim that 'existence precedes essence' succeed in grounding human freedom?"

How would you answer this question?

Usual steps might be to Google the question, to prompt an AI model to provide an overview and answer? Better still, it might be to research Sartre: turn to his original works and claims.

These are all reasonable starting points, but before all of that - find the claim.

Finding the claim

Question: *"To what extent does Sartre's claim that 'existence precedes essence' succeed in grounding human freedom?"*

Claim: *~~"To what extent does~~ Sartre's claim that 'existence precedes essence' succeed(s) in grounding human freedom?"*

Outcome: I need to explore whether Sartre's claim that 'existence precedes essence' succeeds in grounding human freedom

That's the basis of the question; it's a question about that claim, and it's asking you to decide to what extent the claim is strong or weak. That's what you are being asked to analyse, critique, evaluate, and decide. Once you know that, you have a direction. Everything else flows from it.

The best thing is you can do this for every question, and once you've got it, you can build on it.

Finding the *basis* behind the claim

Once you have the claim, the next step is to find out why someone would make it. In other words: what is the reasoning behind the claim? To do this, you need to research. You want to get as close to the original source as possible. For our Sartre question, that means going to his actual writing. Here is the key passage, from his lecture *Existentialism is a Humanism*:

"What do we mean by saying that existence precedes essence? We mean that man first of all exists, encounters himself, surges up in the world – and defines himself afterwards. If man as the existentialist sees him is not definable, it is because to begin with he is nothing."

But we aren't just looking for a definition of the phrase. We're looking for how this succeeds in grounding human freedom. So we go back to the sources:

"He will not be anything until later, and then he will be what he makes of himself. Thus, there is no human nature, because there is no God to have a conception of it. Man simply is."

And there it is. The basis behind the claim: there is no God to have a conception of our nature, so there is no nature, and it is our responsibility to define our existence for ourselves. That is how existence precedes essence is claimed to ground human freedom.

Evaluate the basis, and the claim

Once you have the basis behind the claim, you evaluate it. This is where most students make or break their argument. Here are two examples of evaluation at different levels. Both are responding to the claim that ‘existence precedes essence’ successfully grounds human freedom.

EVALUATION 1

The claim is correct because I agree that God doesn’t exist and therefore it is up to us to decide how to live. This is because no one has ever seen God in the sky and as a result there is no evidence that God exists. Because this means God doesn’t exist, and therefore that no one can tell us what to do, the only other person it could be is myself, and therefore I must exist first and then define myself.

EVALUATION 2

The claim is correct on the condition that all arguments in favour of the existence of God are incorrect. This is because atheism is a prerequisite to the idea that we define our existence for ourselves. If atheism is proven, then human freedom is not the result of an entity separate to ourselves, and is instead the result of our capacity for self-definition. That said, Sartre’s statement does not discuss evolution as a potential basis for human freedom. The evidence is also only taken from one piece of work, and it is known that Sartre rejected the validity of the work after it was produced.

The difference is clear. Evaluation 2 is a much stronger evaluation. But there’s an important twist: it’s also a much weaker *answer*.

Evaluation 2 identifies various conditions that need to be satisfied in order for the claim to be correct, but it doesn’t actually state whether those conditions are met. It raises more questions than it started with. Evaluation 1, despite having weak reasoning, at least commits to an answer.

What you need, ultimately, is both: a thorough evaluation *and* a clear answer. How to achieve that is what Part Two is about.

KEY TAKEAWAY

Before you research, find the claim in the question. Everything you read, evaluate, and write should be in service of deciding whether that claim is true.

PART TWO

Evidence and Logical Reasoning

Different fields use different evidence

The types of evidence that are appealed to in physics, neuroscience, psychology, philosophy, and English literature are all very different.

If you told a neuroscientist researching free will that Sartre has already found the answer: “his freedom is grounded in the idea that our existence precedes our essence” — you would, at the least, get a very funny look.

Not because the claim is necessarily wrong. But because you would be appealing to a form of evidence that isn’t appropriate within the field of neuroscience. That kind of error is called a **category mistake**, and it’s one of the most common weaknesses I see in student essays.

Within philosophy, the two main forms of evidence are logical reasoning and conceptual analysis. For now, I’ll focus on the first, which is the foundation of almost all philosophical arguments.

Logical reasoning

At its core, philosophy analyses arguments about ideas and appeals to logic to verify their cogency: how correct they are. The primary tool for this is the deductive argument. Here is the most famous example:

P1 All humans are mortal

P2 Socrates is a human

∴ **Socrates is mortal**

Both premises are true, and they logically lead to the conclusion. This is what a **sound argument** looks like. When you produce philosophical arguments, you want to use this structure to validate their cogency.

Applying logical reasoning in practice

Let’s take the concept of freedom, and think through how logical reasoning works in an essay context. Imagine you’re arguing against including ‘rights’ in the definition of freedom. Your claim: the right to freedom is irrelevant to definitions of freedom, because freedom can exist whether there is a right to it or not. A prisoner of war has no right to be free, but they still have the power to escape.

Here’s the logical argument underpinning that claim:

P1 You can be free without having the right to be free

P2 You cannot be free without the power to be free

∴ **Freedom can be defined without rights**

This is a classically philosophical approach: appealing to deductive reasoning as the basis for your position. But this doesn't mean the logic can't be disputed. Someone might counter:

- P1 To believe is to accept a fact of reality
- P2 To believe in one's right to be free is to accept that freedom is a fact of reality
- P3 Believing in a fact of reality empowers action in relation to that fact

∴ **The right to be free motivates the power to be free**

Philosophy works like this: a game of structured argument and counter-argument, where the strongest position is the one that no one can effectively refute. The goal in your essay is to anticipate those counter-arguments and address them before someone else does.

Returning to our two evaluations

What's wrong with Evaluation 1?

Evaluation 1 claimed God doesn't exist because "no one has ever seen God in the sky." Let's use logical reasoning to evaluate the quality.

- P1 It is possible that God exists even if God does not exist in the sky
- P2 God not existing is integral to Sartre's argument that existence precedes essence

∴ **This evaluation of Sartre's argument is weak**

We've identified a claim that doesn't hold, and used logical reasoning to show why.

What's wrong with Evaluation 2?

Evaluation 2 raised evolution as a possible counter-argument to Sartre. Here's the problem:

- P1 Evolution is a scientific phenomenon
- P2 Sartre's argument is standardly non-scientific

∴ **Appealing only to evolution to evaluate Sartre is a category error**

Sartre's account of freedom isn't meant to be compared to scientific reasoning. It's a response to a specific philosophical tradition: the idea that essence precedes existence. Introducing evolution as a counter-argument is appealing to the wrong kind of evidence for the wrong kind of claim.

KEY TAKEAWAY

Use logical reasoning to test your claims. Structure your arguments as premises leading to a conclusion. Identify and address counter-arguments. And avoid category errors — always appeal to evidence that is appropriate to your field.

So which evaluation is better?

Evaluation 2 is better as an *evaluation* - it anticipates issues, identifies conditions, and shows genuine philosophical awareness.

But Evaluation 1 is better as an *answer* - it commits to a position.

In an ideal essay, you want both: a good evaluation and a clear answer. The final part of this guide is about how to produce exactly that.

PART THREE

Answering the Question

The most painful question you can ask yourself: “**Does my essay actually answer the question?**”

It is the most painful question you can ask yourself in academic essay writing, especially at 11:12 PM before an 11:59 PM deadline.

Here’s the uncomfortable truth: after all the research, all the analysis, and all the writing, many students produce essays that don’t actually answer the question they were given.

Instead, it’s common that they’ve produced excellent essays on only certain aspects of the topic, aspects that they were interested in. In relation to the actual question, it is more likely tangential rather than something responsive.

The two techniques below exist to prevent that from happening.

Technique 1: Mirroring

Mirroring emerged from the countless times a teacher or professor told me they couldn’t clearly identify my answer to the essay question. It’s now one of the first exercises I do with every student I work with, and it works.

The strategy is simple: frame your answer to the question using the **exact wording** of the question. With our working example:

QUESTION

“To what extent does Sartre’s claim that ‘existence precedes essence’ succeed in grounding human freedom?”

MIRRORED

“Sartre’s claim that ‘existence precedes essence’ succeeds in grounding human freedom to [some] extent. This is because...”

Obvious? Maybe. But so often when we’re deep in a topic, we start with the thinker’s ideas and forget to address the actual question. Using this technique when you first begin drafting will do wonders for focus and accuracy.

Technique 2: The Cross-Check

Even if you didn’t use mirroring, the cross-check will catch problems before they cost you marks. Once you have a complete draft, go back to the original claim you identified in Part One, and match it to your conclusion. Ask: *does what I’ve written actually answer the question?*

A common but weak conclusion

WEAK CONCLUSION

Sartre’s claim is an enlightening way of understanding and defining the nature of human freedom, and while it has many challenges, will remain as an excellent philosophical account.

Not bad on the surface. It acknowledges the debate and treats the subject with respect. But academically, it’s not great. Why? Because it doesn’t answer the question. The question asks about the *success* of the claim in grounding human freedom: **to what extent does it succeed?**

Is it successful, unsuccessful, or does it depend?

The answer above sidesteps all of that.

A stronger conclusion

STRONG CONCLUSION

In conclusion, Sartre's claim that human 'existence precedes essence' is successful ground for human freedom. As outlined, the extent of its success is contingent on the validity of the argument for the existence of God, as well as the validity of the philosophical perspective that underpins the claim. Given that we have shown the argument for the existence of God to be invalid, and the philosophical perspective to be valid, the claim is successful to a great extent, and is testament to the insight within Jean-Paul Sartre's philosophy.

This second answer speaks directly to the success-condition of the question. It addresses the extent of the success, explains what it depends on, and states a clear position. So long as the arguments in the essay were as strong as they sound here, this is an excellent answer.

Make the answer obvious

The overarching principle across both techniques is this: **make the answer obvious**.

This doesn't just apply to your conclusion. It applies to every idea you convey, every structure you impose, every word you choose. From the very first sentence, the examiner should be able to see where you're going.

Consider **the examiner** for a moment. Think about how many essays they might have read that morning, that day, that week. If your essay is confusing and your answer is hard to find, the examiner will not look for it.

So make it easy for them. A clear essay is an essay that gets marked on its merits.

KEY TAKEAWAY

Use mirroring at the start of drafting to keep your answer on track. Use the cross-check at the end to verify you've actually answered the question. Above all: make the answer obvious.

The Complete Process

I hope this has been of some help. Here's a summary of what we've covered:

BEFORE YOU WRITE

- Find the claim in the question: the statement being put in question by the question mark.
- Research the basis behind the claim: go as close to the primary source as possible.
- Identify the type of evidence appropriate to your field: don't commit category errors.
- Use mirroring to frame your initial answer using the wording of the question.

AS YOU WRITE

- Build your argument using logical reasoning: premises that lead clearly to a conclusion.
- Anticipate counter-arguments and address them: the strongest essays pre-empt objections.
- Keep returning to the question: every paragraph should earn its place in your answer.

AFTER YOU WRITE

- Cross-check: does your conclusion actually answer the question that was asked?
- If not, work back through the essay and identify which paragraphs are off-track.
- Make the answer obvious: a marker who has to search for it won't reward it.

A Final Note

This guide is only the beginning.

Essay writing is a skill, and like any skill, it develops through practice.. The value of this framework is in applying it: to real questions, under real conditions, and with someone who can push back on your reasoning when it's weak.

That's the kind of work I do with students at BFD Tutors.

If you'd like to apply this framework to your own essays, work through a question together, or develop your philosophical writing more broadly, I'd be glad to hear from you.

Sam Finnegan-Dehn

BFD Tutors

sam@bfdtutors.com

bfdtutors.com